ORTING ARENA



SUSHIL DHARGAVE

infrastructure during the nationals and found it to be up to international standard," says Sultan Singh, secretary general, National Rifle Association of India (NRAI), speaking to INDIA TODAY on how Bhopal bagged the coveted ISSF event that will have 325 shooters from 33 countries vying for top honours. "Based on it, we pitched the city as a possible venue for the World Cup, which was accepted by the international federation."

The world-class infrastructure has also produced medal winners like Aishwary Pratap Singh Tomar, 22, a product of the Madhya Pradesh Shooting Academy and a junior world record-holder in the rifle event. Then there are trap shooters Manisha Keer, 23, and Varsha Varman, 28, who have won laurels for the country on international platforms. Also Vivek Sagar, 23, who was part of the Indian men's hockey team that won the bronze at the 2020 Olympics. Grabbing 96 medals, including 39 gold, 30 silver and 27 bronze, the state's athletes helped it finish third—behind only Maharashtra and Haryana—in the Youth Games.

Today, the department of sports and youth welfare is running 10 sports academies, with Bhopal alone home to six: shooting, water sports, equestrian, martial arts, men's hockey and athletics. The women's hockey and badminton academies have been established in Gwalior, and archery and cricket academies are in Jabalpur and Shivpuri, respectively. Equipped with state-of-the-art infrastructure and top national and international coaches, these academies help identify Madhya Pradesh's sporting talent at an early stage and provide them with stay, diet and training to excel in their discipline. Then, there are the multiple stadiums—multidiscipline and single sports, indoor and outdoor—that have come up on a massive scale, not just at the district level but at the sub-district, tehsil and block level too. With the construction of 44 more stadiums expected to get completed by the end of this year, sources in the sports department claim the number will cross 150 from the present 107.

That isn't all. Sports minister Yashodhara Raje Scindia, who has been driving the government's efforts, has set even more ambitious targets. "We are now looking ahead," she says. "We will be building one indoor stadium in each of the 230 assembly segments of the state and one multidiscipline sports stadium in each of the 52 districts." The plan is to connect sports academies located in prominent cities of MP with feeder centres located in districts, the minister explains further. "This will help identify and nurture talent at the grassroots level."

In the new budget, the MP government has allocated Rs 149 crore for the construction of sports stadiums, Rs 130 crore for academies and Rs 349 crore for establishing infrastructure under Khelo India. This zeal and impetus can be traced back to the state's New Sports Policy, 2005, that gave a big push to create a "healthy pool" of athletes by organising regular sports events and improving infrastructure. Close on its heels, Scindia was appointed the sports minister in December 2005. But after she got elected to the Lok Sabha in 2007, most of the initiatives came to a grinding halt, only to be revived in January 2014 when she returned at the helm.

The state's ascent in the sporting arena has also proved to be a boon for the realty and hospitality sector in the capital city. "The number of big sporting events being held here has opened up new opportunities for the hospitality sector," says Faiz Rashid, director of the Bhopal-based Jehan Numa Group of heritage hotels. Amid a spurt in demand for rooms to accommodate the athletes, coaches and administrators who have been landing in Bhopal for training camps and tournaments, many new guesthouses have mushroomed near the shooting range and other academies. But Bhopal's poor air connectivity remains a major drawback, say locals. State's athletes and coaches also often complain of delay in payments for their travel due to alleged red-tapism when it comes to the disbursal of funds allocated in the budget.

Even in the sporting arena, there's the potential to achieve greater heights. For instance, at the National Games in 2007, MP finished overall 12th with 63 medals, of which just 12 were gold. Fifteen years later, in the latest edition held in Gujarat in 2022, the state stood seventh with 66 medals, including 20 gold—an improvement but still far below potential. Given the present momentum, Madhya Pradesh must shoot for the stars. ■